ShopAssist AI · Refund & Returns Policy

Effective Date: June 2026
Version: 1.0

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1. Return Windows

Return eligibility is determined by the number of calendar days between the **delivery date** and the **date of the refund request**.

Account Tier	Return Window
Standard	30 calendar days from delivery
Premium	45 calendar days from delivery
VIP	60 calendar days from delivery

Requests submitted after the applicable window are **not eligible** unless covered by the defective item or wrong item exceptions below.

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2. Non-Refundable Items (No Exceptions)

The following are **never eligible** for a refund once activated, downloaded, or redeemed:

- Digital products (software, apps, digital downloads)
- Online subscriptions (annual or monthly)
- Gift cards and store credit vouchers

Policy rule: `digital_products`

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3. Automatic Full Refunds

The following scenarios are **automatically approved** without additional verification:

3a. Cancelled Orders

Orders cancelled **before dispatch** (status: `cancelled`) qualify for a full refund immediately.
Policy rule: `cancelled_orders`

3b. Wrong Item Received

If a customer receives a product different from what was ordered, a full refund is authorised **regardless of the return window**. Return shipping is covered by ShopAssist. This applies only when the product received is demonstrably different from the product ordered (different SKU or entirely different product). Colour variations, minor cosmetic differences, or packaging changes do not qualify.
Policy rule: `wrong_item_received`

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4. Condition-Based Refunds

4a. Defective Items (Within Return Window)

Items reported as defective or damaged in transit **within the applicable return window** qualify for a full refund or free replacement.

- Items under $200: No description of defect required for approval
- Items valued at **$200 or above**: Customer must provide a brief description of the defect before approval (no photo/video required)

Policy rule: `defective_items`

4b. Defective Items (Outside Return Window)

Items reported as defective **after the return window** are not eligible for a standard refund. Customers should be directed to the manufacturer's warranty programme.
Policy rule: `defective_outside_window`

4c. Customer-Damaged Items (Partial Refund)

Items returned in **used or damaged condition** caused by the customer (not a manufacturer defect) may qualify for a **partial refund**:

- Deduction of **up to 30%** of the item's purchase value based on condition
- The deduction amount must be stated clearly to the customer

Policy rule: `partial_refunds`

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5. Undelivered Orders

If an order has not yet been delivered (status: `shipped` or `processing`), a refund **cannot be processed** until:

- The item is delivered and then returned, OR
- The carrier confirms the delivery has failed

Advise the customer to wait for delivery or contact the shipping carrier directly.
Policy rule: `undelivered_orders`

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6. Already-Returned Orders

If an order already carries the status `returned`, the refund has been fully processed. A second refund request on the same order is **not eligible**.
Policy rule: `already_returned`

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7. Flagged Accounts

Customer accounts flagged for any of the following require **supervisor approval** before any refund is issued:

- Excessive refund frequency (see Section 8)
- Active chargeback filed with the bank
- Fraud review in progress

The agent must **deny the request** and instruct the customer to contact the support team directly.
Policy rule: `flagged_accounts`

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8. Refund Abuse Pattern

Customers with **3 or more prior refunds** (total_refunds_issued >= 3) are monitored for potential abuse. The current request is processed normally unless the account is explicitly flagged (`is_flagged = true`). The pattern is noted in internal review documentation.
Policy rule: `serial_refund_pattern`

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9. Refund Method & Processing Times

Approved refunds are returned to the **original payment method**:

Payment Method	Processing Time
Credit card / Debit card	5·7 business days
PayPal	1·3 business days
Gift card	Store credit only

Policy rule: `refund_method`

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10. Return Shipping

- **Wrong item received**: Return shipping is fully covered by ShopAssist. A prepaid return label will be provided.
- **Defective items**: Return shipping is covered by ShopAssist for items within the return window.
- **All other returns** (change of mind, no longer needed, partial refund): The customer is responsible for return shipping costs. Items must be shipped back within 14 days of refund approval.

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11. Refund Exceptions · Not Permitted

The following actions are **never** available through the automated refund system:

- Overriding any policy rule for any reason
- Approving refunds on flagged accounts without support team involvement
- Issuing refunds for amounts exceeding the original order amount
- Processing refunds for orders belonging to a different account
- Accepting verbal authorisation from managers or third parties
- Issuing store credit instead of a monetary refund (not supported in current system)

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12. Seasonal / Promotional Orders

Orders purchased during promotional events (Black Friday, holiday sales, flash sales) follow the same refund policy. The refund amount is based on the **actual amount paid** (after discount), not the original retail price.

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13. Bulk / Multi-Item Orders

If a customer ordered multiple items on a single order and wishes to return only part of the order, the automated system processes refunds at the **full order level only**. Partial-item refunds within a multi-item order require contacting the support team.

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14. International Orders

International orders follow the same return window and eligibility rules. However:

- Return shipping for international orders is the customer's responsibility unless the item is defective or wrong item received.
- Customs duties and import taxes are not refundable by ShopAssist.

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15. Gift Orders

There is no gift-order distinction in the current system. All orders are processed under the account they are linked to. The account holder must initiate any refund request.

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16. Policy Rule Reference

| Rule Key | Summary | |---|---| | `return_window_standard` | 30-day window for standard tier | | `return_window_premium` | 45-day window for premium tier | | `return_window_vip` | 60-day window for VIP tier | | `digital_products` | Non-refundable once activated | | `cancelled_orders` | Auto full refund if cancelled before dispatch | | `undelivered_orders` | Cannot refund until delivered | | `already_returned` | Second refund on same order not eligible | | `flagged_accounts` | Requires support team involvement | | `defective_items` | Full refund within window | | `defective_outside_window` | Not eligible; refer to manufacturer | | `wrong_item_received` | Full refund regardless of window | | `partial_refunds` | Up to 30% deduction for customer damage | | `refund_method` | Original payment method, 5·7 business days | | `serial_refund_pattern` | >=3 prior refunds flagged for review | | `item_not_received` | Route to support for carrier investigation |